

Minerals gamble: On the U.S.-Ukraine mineral deal

The **pact** with the U.S. **does** little for Ukraine's security

After **painstaking** negotiations, **marked** by **inflammatory exchanges**, Washington and Kyiv have signed an agreement that would grant the U.S. access to Ukraine's critical mineral and oil and gas resources through a joint investment fund. Ukraine has **claimed** that it would **lead to** an equal economic partnership, while its actual impact remains uncertain. The **idea** of a minerals deal **was proposed** by Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy last year to the Biden administration as part of his "victory plan". His pitch was to open up Ukraine's **vast untapped** critical minerals resources (which include lithium, graphite, uranium and titanium, besides rare earth minerals) in exchange for continued American military support and security guarantees. After Donald Trump **assumed** the **presidency**, he supported a minerals deal, but an **entirely** different one. He **insisted** that Kyiv repay the billions of dollars provided as military and economic **assistance** during the war by granting U.S. companies access to Ukraine's resources. At one point, the **disagreement escalated** into a public **spat** at **the Oval Office** between Mr. Zelenskyy and Mr. Trump. But both sides **pressed ahead**, which **culminated** in the April 30 deal.

For Ukraine, the agreement represents an improvement over Mr. Trump's previous proposals. There is no reference to **aid** as **debt** in **the fine print**. Under the deal, the United States-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund will **finance extraction** projects in Ukraine's resources. Kyiv will share 50% of the revenues from these projects towards the fund. While the agreement **omits** any reference to past U.S. aid, future American assistance will be considered as capital contributions to the fund — Ukraine will have to repay future aid through resource revenues. More importantly, although Mr. Zelenskyy originally **envisioned** a minerals deal as a pathway to **securing** security guarantees from the U.S., the final agreement offers no **explicit** American security **commitments** to Kyiv. Ukrainian officials have **portrayed** the deal, which needs to be **ratified** by Parliament, as a win-win. But it actually **underscores** Kyiv's growing **vulnerabilities** in a war that shows no sign of **abating**. Mr. Zelenskyy and his generals are aware that if American support **dries up**, their **embattled** forces would be **in peril**. And Mr. Trump has already rejected Ukraine's most **pressing** demand — **firm** security guarantees. Facing limited options, Ukraine has signed the agreement in the hope that it would at least ensure continued flow of U.S. military assistance in the form of U.S. investments to the fund. But Mr. Zelenskyy's minerals gamble will **pay off** only if the Trump administration stays **committed** to helping end the war. If the war **drags on**, with Russia forces continuing to **advance** in the east, the minerals **deal would** mean little for Ukraine's security.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

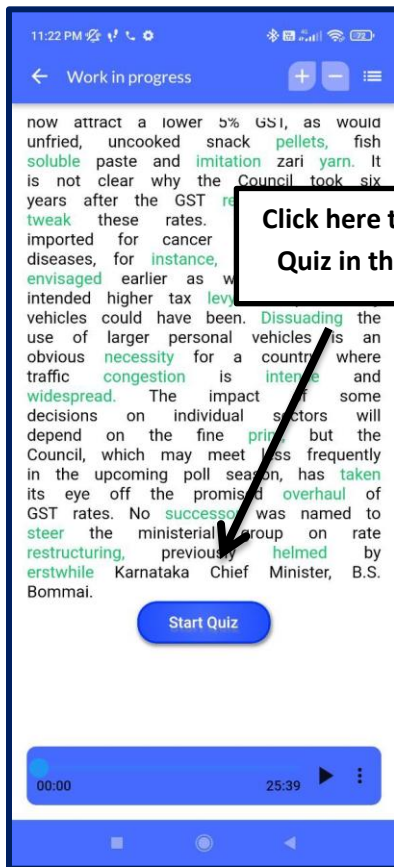
1. **Gamble** (noun) – risk, venture, speculation, bet, chance जोखिम
2. **Pact** (noun) – agreement, treaty, deal, contract, accord समझौता
3. **Painstaking** (adjective) – meticulous, thorough, careful, diligent, exacting परिश्रमी / सावधानीपूर्वक
4. **Mark** (verb) – indicate, signify, characterize, denote, highlight चिह्नित करना
5. **Inflammatory** (adjective) – provocative, inciting, incendiary, agitating, offensive भड़काऊ
6. **Exchange** (noun) – conversation, communication, interaction, dialogue, trade वार्ता
7. **Claim** (verb) – assert, declare, maintain, state, allege दावा करना
8. **Lead** (to) (verb) – cause, result in, bring about, produce, generate वजह बनना
9. **Propose** (verb) – suggest, offer, recommend, present, put forward प्रस्ताव करना
10. **Vast** (adjective) – immense, huge, extensive, massive, enormous विशाल
11. **Untapped** (adjective) – unused, undiscovered, unexploited, dormant, hidden अप्रयुक्त
12. **Assume** (verb) – take on, adopt, accept, undertake, acquire ग्रहण करना
13. **Presidency** (noun) – administration, leadership, office, rule, term राष्ट्रपति पद
14. **Entirely** (adverb) – completely, wholly, fully, absolutely, totally पूरी तरह से
15. **Insist** (verb) – demand, urge, emphasize, assert, require जोर देना
16. **Assistance** (noun) – help, support, aid, backing, cooperation सहायता
17. **Disagreement** (noun) – conflict, dispute, difference, dissent, quarrel असहमति
18. **Escalate** (verb) – intensify, increase, heighten, worsen, aggravate बढ़ना / उग्र होना
19. **Spat** (noun) – quarrel, argument, dispute, squabble, tiff झगड़ा
20. **The Oval Office** (noun) – U.S. President's official office राष्ट्रपति कार्यालय
21. **Press ahead** (phrasal verb) – continue, move forward, push on, proceed, advance आगे बढ़ना

22. **Culminate** (verb) – end, result, conclude, finish, reach a peak समाप्त होना / चरम पर पहुँचना
23. **Aid** (verb) – help, assist, support, facilitate, contribute सहायता करना
24. **Debt** (noun) – obligation, liability, dues, borrowing, credit कर्ज
25. **The fine print** (noun) – details, small print, hidden clauses, specifics, conditions बारीक शर्तें / नियम
26. **Finance** (verb) – fund, invest in, sponsor, underwrite, support वित्त पोषण करना
27. **Extraction** (noun) – removal, mining, withdrawal, excavation, drawing निष्कर्षण
28. **Omit** (verb) – leave out, exclude, skip, neglect, overlook छोड़ देना
29. **Envision** (verb) – imagine, foresee, conceive, visualize, plan कल्पना करना
30. **Secure** (verb) – obtain, acquire, ensure, achieve, gain सुरक्षित करना / प्राप्त करना
31. **Explicit** (adjective) – clear, direct, definite, specific, unambiguous स्पष्ट
32. **Commitment** (noun) – pledge, promise, assurance, obligation, responsibility प्रतिबद्धता
33. **Portray** (verb) – depict, represent, describe, illustrate, present चित्रित करना
34. **Ratify** (verb) – approve, confirm, endorse, validate, sanction पुष्टि करना
35. **Underscore** (verb) – emphasize, highlight, stress, accentuate, reinforce ज़ोर देना
36. **Vulnerability** (noun) – weakness, susceptibility, exposure, fragility, risk कमजोरी / असुरक्षा
37. **Abate** (verb) – lessen, reduce, diminish, ease, subside कम होना
38. **Pressing** (adjective) – urgent, critical, crucial, important, immediate अत्यावश्यक
39. **Firm** (adjective) – strong, resolute, solid, steady, unwavering दृढ़
40. **Pay off** (phrasal verb) – succeed, bring results, be worthwhile, prove effective, reward सफल होना / लाभदायक होना
41. **Committed** (adjective) – dedicated, devoted, loyal, resolute, steadfast प्रतिबद्ध
42. **Drag on** (phrasal verb) – continue, linger, stretch, prolong, persist लंबे समय तक खिंचना
43. **Advance** (verb) – move forward, proceed, progress, approach, push ahead आगे बढ़ना

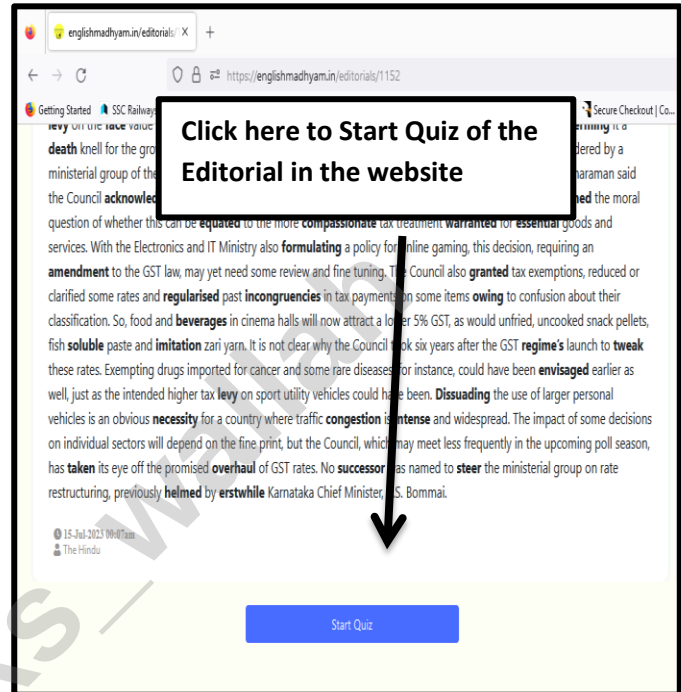
Summary of the Editorial

1. The U.S. and Ukraine have signed a deal giving the U.S. access to Ukraine's critical mineral and energy resources through a joint investment fund.
2. Ukraine hopes this deal will lead to economic partnership and continued U.S. support, though its real impact is uncertain.
3. President Zelenskyy initially proposed the deal in 2023 as part of his "victory plan," linking mineral access to American military aid.
4. The minerals in question include lithium, graphite, uranium, titanium, and rare earth elements.
5. Donald Trump supported a mineral deal too, but demanded repayment of U.S. aid via access to Ukraine's resources.
6. This demand led to tensions, including a public argument between Trump and Zelenskyy in the Oval Office.
7. The current deal is seen by Ukraine as better than Trump's earlier proposals, as it does not retroactively treat past aid as debt.
8. The agreement establishes a U.S.-Ukraine Reconstruction Investment Fund to finance extraction projects.
9. Ukraine will share 50% of revenues from resource projects with this fund.
10. Future U.S. aid will be treated as capital investments to be repaid through resource revenues.
11. Crucially, the deal does **not** provide any U.S. security guarantees, despite Zelenskyy's original expectations.
12. Ukrainian officials present the agreement as mutually beneficial, but it reflects Ukraine's vulnerable position in an ongoing war.
13. Zelenskyy is concerned that without continued U.S. support, Ukrainian forces could face collapse.
14. Trump has already refused Ukraine's demand for binding security guarantees.
15. The deal is a risky gamble by Ukraine, which will only help if the U.S. remains committed to supporting Ukraine against Russia.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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